

Eating to Support Healthy Cholesterol

VGH Centre for Cardiovascular Health



The Portfolio Diet: Nature's Cholesterol Fighters

Did you know that only plant-based foods, including healthy plant fats, have the ability to lower LDL ("bad") cholesterol?

Certain plant foods contain natural compounds that actively lower LDL cholesterol. When these foods are eaten together on a regular basis, they form what is known as the **Portfolio Diet**—one of the most effective dietary approaches for lowering cholesterol naturally.

Research has shown that combining these foods every day can lower LDL cholesterol by **20–30%** in some people, especially when combined with other heart-healthy lifestyle habits. Each food works in a different way—some reduce cholesterol absorption, others help remove cholesterol from the body, while others reduce the amount of cholesterol your liver produces.

The Cholesterol-Lowering Four

- ♥ **Soluble Fibre** – pulls cholesterol out of the body
- ♥ **Plant Sterols** – blocks cholesterol absorption
- ♥ **Nuts** – provide healthy fats, fibre and plant sterols
- ♥ **Soy Protein** – replaces animal protein and helps lower LDL

Soluble Fibre

Soluble fibre forms a gel in your digestive tract that binds to bile acids (made from cholesterol) and removes them from the body. Your liver must then use cholesterol to make more bile, helping lower LDL cholesterol.

Good sources include:

- Oats and oat bran
- Barley, dried beans, lentils and chickpeas
- Apples and citrus fruit
- Ground flaxseed, Chia seeds
- Psyllium (Metamucil®)

Plant Sterols

Plant sterols naturally compete with cholesterol for absorption in the intestine, so less cholesterol enters your bloodstream.

Aim for **2 grams daily**. Because it is difficult to get enough plant sterols from food alone, some people may

benefit from a supplement. **CardioSmile®** is my preferred option as it provides plant sterols and may also help lower triglycerides while modestly increasing HDL ("good") cholesterol. However, supplements need to be taken every day, can be costly, and are best used **in addition to**—not instead of—a cholesterol-lowering eating pattern

Nuts

A small handful of nuts each day can help lower LDL cholesterol. Nuts provide healthy unsaturated fats, fibre and plant sterols while replacing less healthy snack choices. Aim for **¼ cup (30 g) daily or 1 to 2 tablespoons of nut butter (e.g. natural peanut butter, almond butter)**. Choose your favourites, almonds, walnuts, pecans, cashews, peanuts.

Soy Protein

Replacing some animal proteins with soy foods helps lower LDL cholesterol while adding more plant protein to your diet. Easy ways to include soy such as different textures of tofu, edamame, unsweetened soy milk.

Did You Know?

Each of the Cholesterol-Lowering Four works differently. When combined together as part of the Portfolio Diet, they have a much greater cholesterol-lowering effect than any one food alone. Research has shown that including these foods regularly can lower LDL cholesterol by up to 30% in some people, especially when combined with other heart-healthy lifestyle habits

Think "ADD" rather than "AVOID." Focus on adding the Cholesterol-Lowering Four to your meals whenever you can. Every meal is an opportunity to make a heart-healthy choice and over time, these small changes can make a meaningful difference to your LDL cholesterol and overall heart health. ***Even if you are taking cholesterol-lowering medication, these foods continue to benefit your heart by helping reduce inflammation and supporting healthy blood vessels.***

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